

PROTECTIVE

Kanchan Ray, 55
Devdutta Ray, 17

KOLKATA

Dropping off, picking up, checking on friends, asking the driver to keep watch—he does all that to save his daughter from the big bad world out there.

“WE WON’T LET HER OPT FOR A COLLEGE OUT OF TOWN. SHE’S TOO SHY. HOW CAN SHE MANAGE WITHOUT US?”

go out on their own, without their children. And if they do, they make sure it's when the kids are at school. Tanvi, a 32-year-old homemaker who spends most of the day with her children, admits candidly that she “lives for them”. “My parents weren’t too involved,” she says. “We lived in a big joint family and there wasn’t much time.” Things have certainly changed for her children. “Today, we want to share everything with the kids, and we have very different expectations of them.” Expectations that make her put her 10-year-old daughter, Akanksha, through a gruelling series of daily activities. Akanksha has been swimming since she was six and is already a state-level swimmer. She also knows skating and is adept at chess. “I want her to know and experience all these activities, so that she never feels awkward socially,” says Tanvi, who still feels acutely about her inability to swim when she goes for visits with friends and family.

The “hovering” starts early, as witnessed by Amitha Prasath, the principal of Prayag Montessori in Bangalore. She cites the example of a young couple, both IT graduates, who

asked a teacher how they could help their then two-year-old child achieve even more dazzling academic heights. “Agreed, today’s world does demand more from our children, and active parental involvement from us. But every child has his or her individuality and limits,” says Prasath. Such overzealous parents can turn out to be a teacher’s bane. Ask Devi Kar, principal, Modern High School for Girls, Kolkata. “Parents often ring each other up to discuss class notes, or get worried when a child reports something that happened in school,” she says. “They don’t weigh the possible option—that maybe the child is magnifying the problem—or try to understand the situation before questioning a teacher’s remark.”

But, then, it isn’t really easy to be a parent now, is it? The world has opened up and, with it, a slew of powerful new influences: Television, cellphone, Internet, the list goes on. Who wouldn’t consider keeping a careful eye on their child, particularly those trouble-prone teenagers?

Bina Shreedar, from Bangalore, chaperones her 13-year-old son, Varun, as much as she can. The 43-year-old homemaker and her husband also try to monitor what Varun and his older brother, Ashish, 17, watch on TV or the Internet. “I have put a password on the computer, and try to hang around when they surf the Net.” She adds, “I check the history of the Internet sites they visit.”

In an effort to be aware of every aspect of their child’s life, and therefore control it, a lot of parents take the ‘friend’ approach. “The ‘buddy-parent’ trend is emerging in urban society to redefine the concept of effective parenting,” says Jeetendra Nagpal, psychiatrist at VIMHANS. Unfortunately, buddy parents often turn overprotective due to lack of faith, and time for their child. “Effective parenting turns into anxious and authoritarian parenting,” Nagpal points out.

Neenu Nayyar has struck up exactly such a buddy-parent relationship with her daughter Shameen. The 35-year-old Noida homemaker is emphatic: Her 13-year-old daughter is her best friend. “She never hides anything from me. I’m friends with all her friends and they share all the school gossip with me. I mingle with her friends’ parents to make sure she’s in good company.”

VITAL SIGNS

How to recognise the breed:

QUICK FIXERS

Always opt for shot gun solutions to suit their child. If the child does not like a teacher, parents will demand the principal replace him or her.

RANTERS & RAVERS

Loudly complain about anything that doesn’t go their child’s way; always crib about unfair treatment or about losing out to those with better contacts.

ATTENTION SEEKERS

Believe that the world revolves around their child. If their kids want to run up and down airplane aisles, so be it. Be expected to ooh and aah over them.

RULE BREAKERS

Show little respect for the views and needs of others, or for authority. They always side with their child, no matter how poorly behaved or bratty.

A TELLTALE SIGN: PARENTS MASQUERADING AS THEIR CHILD ONLINE.